



SAY CHEESE!

Cheese is finally coming of age in India with various artisanal brands providing soft and hard cheeses that hold their own against their western counterparts

BY SMITA TRIPATHI

THIRTY-FIVE-YEAR-OLD advertising professional Nandini Dhingra is a self-confessed ‘cheese-aholic’. “I can have cheese any time of day and night,” says the Bengaluru resident. Her current favourite cheese is called Ode to Chennai—a young Cheddar rubbed with *milagai podi* (gunpowder). The unusual cheese is the brainchild of artisanal cheese maker Namrata Sundaresan who along with her partner Anuradha Krishnamoorthy founded Käse in Chennai in 2016. Käse does a variety of cheeses with a *desi* twist

such as a Pecorino (an Italian sheep-milk cheese) infused with fennel, or a goat cheese that is wrapped in fresh turmeric leaves and then aged for a couple of weeks. “In India we have a very good understanding of spices. So why shouldn’t we use it,” says Sundaresan who gave up a 13-year-long corporate career to turn full-time cheese maker.

Uttarakhand-based Darima Farms offers a cheese called Chilli Bomb that is basically a hard cheese infused with red chillies from Jaisalmer. At Mumbai-based Eleftheria Cheese, artisanal cheese maker Mausam Jotwani Narang has crafted a condiment cheese infused with Himalayan pink salt and rubbed with Kerala black pepper. While that is a popular cheese, it is her take on the Norwegian-style brown cheese Brunost that won her a silver rating at the World Cheese Awards held in Spain in November last year. It’s the first time an Indian cheese won the award, popularly known as the cheese Olympics. The awards had over 4,000 entries from 49 countries.

“Our Brunost is pretty reminiscent of the Indian sweet *peda*. It’s made with Indian milk and Indian whey so it has its own indigenous flavour,” says Narang who also gave up a corporate career to turn cheese maker. She set up Eleftheria (it means freedom in Greek) in 2015 after having made cheese over the weekends for a couple of years while working with a tech multinational. It all started because she wanted to eat good cheese with her bread, the way she had while doing her Masters in the UK. Having not easily found anything she liked, she just started making it on her own. “A hobby that turned into a passion and then an obsession,” she says.